



Joan wrote her first scientific paper at age 19, about a dangerous snake called a pit viper.

Joan became famous around the world for her reptile knowledge. Her most well-known scientific paper shared her discoveries about the pancake tortoise.

As a child, Joan Beauchamp Procter loved reptiles more than books, other pets, and even birthday presents! She longed to study zoology in college, but suffered from frequent illnesses, which made this seem impossible. However, Joan had been writing to the chief herpetologist (person who studies reptiles and amphibians) at the British Museum in the UK. He was so impressed by Joan's knowledge of and enthusiasm for reptiles that he offered her a job at the museum when she graduated school. There, Joan created displays and illustrated postcards. She also began to help to design the homes of animals at the London Zoo, and in 1923, she was offered her dream job—curator, or manager, of the zoo's Reptile House.

Joan was said to keep a pet crocodile in her bathtub, but it was probably just a lizard.

JOAN BEAUCHAMP PROCTER

British zoologist • 1897–1931